

## Mercedes-Benz Group AG (MBGn.DE): Production cost reduction in action - Takeaways from the Kecskemét plant extension trip

**Mercedes-Benz opened the extension of its Kecskemét plant in Hungary, doubling annual capacity to c.400k units** (with full ramp-up expected within 12 months) and making it its largest facility in Europe (and one of the largest globally). Backed by c.€1bn of investment, the extension adds two bodywork/assembly halls, a second press shop, a state-of-the-art paint shop, and a battery assembly facility. Attended by Hungary's Prime Minister and Economy Minister, the ceremony underscored the site's importance to the country's auto value chain. The start of production of the new all-electric C-Class marks the first BEV in Mercedes' Core segment built at the site, alongside the GLB and the exclusive production of the upcoming compact G-Class.

**We attended the opening ceremony and an investor event alongside it on July 13**, where senior management - the CEO, CFO, and Board Member for Production - laid out initiatives on production-cost reduction and humanoid robotics. Having cut global production cost per unit by c.10% in 2022-24, Mercedes targets a further 10% by 2027 (of which 4% was achieved in 2025), with potentially more beyond. The plan centres on raising best-cost-country, building a flexible production network, deepening local-for-local, and cutting structural dependency on Germany, supported by advanced robotics and AI. Additional key takeaways follow:

- **Streamlining global operations through rightsizing capacity and deepening local-for-local.** On capacity, management is committed to a leaner footprint amid heightened demand volatility, targeting 2.4 million units in 2026 and 2.0–2.2 million over the mid term (c.2028), with the primary adjustments falling in China and Germany. In management's view, the world car concept may no longer be suitable for today's environment. Production is becoming increasingly regional, with local-for-local targets of over 85% in Europe and China, and a US ambition to exceed 50% (including the GLC localisation).
- **Moving East is the clear direction, yet Germany remains strategically important.** Kecskemét offers roughly 70% lower factor costs than Germany (due to lower salaries, longer working hours, and markedly lower sick leave), a stable policy environment, EU proximity, and an established supplier base, with the eastward shift now extending beyond vehicle assembly to powertrain and component production (e.g., Romania). The eastward shift now extends beyond vehicle assembly to powertrain and component production (e.g., Romania). Even so, Kecskemét is closely integrated with its two German counterpart plants -

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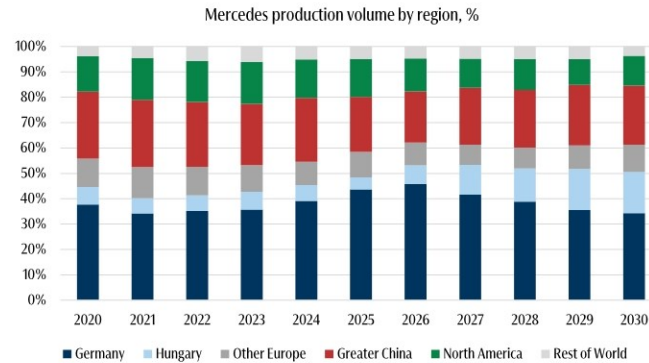
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Rastatt (on the MMA platform) and Bremen (on the MB.EA platform) – forming a flexible production network in which volumes can be shifted between sites according to demand. Germany, for its part, retains a defined role for capability and heritage, particularly for Top-End vehicles, where customers pay a premium for the manufacturing location. It also offers the optionality to leverage Mercedes' industrial capabilities for a growing (but still minor) defence business, some of it with civil applications.

- **Digitalisation underpins an AI-first production process at Kecskemét.** A significant portion of the tour and presentation centered on Mercedes' ambition to lead in next-generation manufacturing. Kecskemét is the first site to feature a complete Digital Factory Twin of an entire assembly hall, built in NVIDIA Omniverse and layered atop the MO360 ecosystem and MO360 Vision System for real-time, camera-based quality control. Management outlined an AI-first production process connecting procurement, production, and sales to detect demand shifts earlier and steer suppliers accordingly. Crucially, as automation and humanoids expand, every production step is captured as data – improving quality and enabling AI to scan the entire process and flag anomalies far earlier.
- **The humanoid partnership with Apptronik bears potential for Mercedes' assembly automation and further applications.** The most forward-looking discussion concerned humanoid robots, developed in partnership with Apptronik (Apollo models). Management sees humanoids as essential to achieving high automation in assembly, where the rate of automation is low and flexible industrial robots fall short, with a roadmap of humanoid training today, production pilots at Sindelfingen by end-2026, and mid-term series integration (subject to safety, regulation, and works-council alignment). Apptronik's CEO Jeff Cardenas emphasised that the collaboration with Mercedes is built on its state-of-the-art industrial manufacturing. Mercedes framed its role as bringing real industrial knowledge and safety/regulatory rigor, while keeping optionality open beyond a single hardware or software provider. Both remain open to exploring commercialisation of the partnership.

**Exhibit 1: Moving East - production volume is expected to grow at a +29% CAGR in 2025-30, while falling -4% in Germany, according to S&P Global.**

Forecast as of Jun-26



Source: S&P Global, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

## Valuation and risks

**Valuation:** We value Mercedes on a hybrid P/E and Daimler Truck (DTG) investment stake framework to explicitly account for the value of the remaining DTG stake. Our 12m price target is **€65** and comprises: (1) €55 per share from applying a 7.5x target multiple on a 50/50 blend of FY27/28E EPS; and (2) €10 per share from the NPV of MBG's DTG stake, assuming an orderly sell-down over five years with proceeds returned to shareholders via MBG share buybacks. We remain **Buy** rated.

**Key downside risks:** Deviation from luxury strategy/focus; slowdown and/or restrictions in key luxury markets; cost savings do not materialise; inability to reduce capex; DTG stake monetisation may be slower or at lower prices than assumed due to market conditions reducing distributable cash and buyback capacity.

|                |                                 |                      |                      |
|----------------|---------------------------------|----------------------|----------------------|
| <b>MBGn.DE</b> | 12m Price Target: <b>€65.00</b> | Price: <b>€45.11</b> | Upside: <b>44.1%</b> |
|----------------|---------------------------------|----------------------|----------------------|

| Buy                                  |                     | GS Forecast |           |           |           |  |
|--------------------------------------|---------------------|-------------|-----------|-----------|-----------|--|
|                                      |                     | 12/25       | 12/26E    | 12/27E    | 12/28E    |  |
| Market cap: €43.4bn / \$49.7bn       | Revenue (€ mn)      | 132,214.0   | 129,414.6 | 132,545.6 | 135,794.7 |  |
| Enterprise value: €66.0bn / \$75.6bn | EBIT (€ mn)         | 8,235.0     | 7,139.0   | 8,416.5   | 9,186.0   |  |
| 3m ADTV: €137.2mn / \$159.4mn        | EPS (€)             | 5.34        | 5.57      | 6.85      | 7.94      |  |
| Germany                              | EV/EBITDA (X)       | 7.0         | 6.2       | 5.5       | 5.2       |  |
| Europe Autos                         | P/E (X)             | 10.2        | 8.1       | 6.6       | 5.7       |  |
| M&A Rank: 3                          | Dividend yield (%)  | 6.4         | 7.8       | 8.6       | 9.3       |  |
| Leases incl. in net debt & EV?: Yes  | FCF yield (%)       | (13.1)      | 12.4      | 11.8      | 15.0      |  |
|                                      | CROCI (%)           | (0.7)       | 16.6      | 15.7      | 16.8      |  |
|                                      | Net debt/EBITDA (X) | 2.2         | 2.0       | 2.0       | 2.0       |  |
|                                      |                     | 3/26        | 6/26E     | 9/26E     | 12/26E    |  |
| EPS (€)                              |                     | 1.49        | 1.43      | 1.30      | 1.35      |  |

Source: Company data, Goldman Sachs Research estimates, FactSet. Price as of 14 Jul 2026 close.



## Disclosure Appendix

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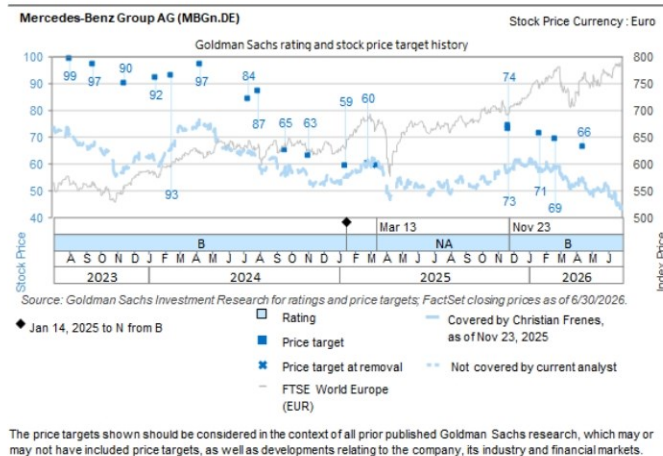
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## Target price history table(s)

### Mercedes-Benz Group AG (MBGn.DE)

| Date of report | Target price (€) | Closing price (€) |
|----------------|------------------|-------------------|
| 14-Jul-26      | 65.00            | 45.11             |
| 16-Apr-26      | 66.00            | 53.35             |
| 20-Feb-26      | 69.00            | 59.24             |
| 23-Jan-26      | 71.00            | 58.30             |
| 24-Nov-25      | 73.00            | 57.49             |
| 23-Nov-25      | 74.00            | 57.02             |
| 25-Feb-25      | 60.00            | 60.70             |
| 14-Jan-25      | 59.00            | 55.55             |
| 05-Nov-24      | 63.00            | 55.90             |
| 20-Sep-24      | 65.00            | 54.99             |
| 31-Jul-24      | 87.00            | 61.16             |
| 12-Jul-24      | 84.00            | 64.78             |
| 11-Apr-24      | 97.00            | 75.74             |
| 14-Feb-24      | 93.00            | 65.53             |
| 16-Jan-24      | 92.00            | 61.28             |
| 17-Nov-23      | 90.00            | 58.60             |
| 18-Sep-23      | 97.00            | 66.44             |
| 02-Aug-23      | 99.00            | 71.05             |

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